Oahu Theological Seminary

IN THE ISLANDS. WITH THE CHURCH. FOR CHRIST'S KINGDOM.

THEO 7004: Systematic Theology 2: Christ, the Spirit, and Salvation

Graduate (MA): 3 credits

Fall 2026 • 7pm – 8:45pm • Aiea Heights Church, Aiea Heights, HI

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Office Hours: By Appointment

§1. COURSE DESCRIPTION

In this course, students will study core doctrines in the Christian faith as revealed in Scripture and taught in the Christian tradition. This course will cover the general topics of Christology, pneumatology, and salvation as well as their more specific sub-topics. Students will learn how such topics are organically related in their material ordering and proportion (system), primarily following the *ordo essendi* (order of being) from a classical theistic perspective, while living out the virtues of faith, hope, and love. In so doing, we will attempt to answer two classic questions in systematic theology—(1) "What does the whole Bible say about [fill in the blank]?"[1] and (2) "what must be true for every exegetical claim to be true?"[2]—that will return us to the Bible and bring us to the contemplation of God.

§2. COURSE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this course, students should:

- Learn the doctrines covered in this course as they are drawn from Scripture and taught in the Christian tradition
- Understand how the topics are organically related to other topics in Christian theology
- Be able to interpret the Bible theologically
- Grow in the Christian virtues of faith, hope, and love
- Know how Christian doctrines fuel and shape the Christian life
- Grow in and spread a passion for the supremacy of God in all things through Jesus Christ

§3. COURSE READINGS

The following books listed below will not be provided by the professor. Students are required to gain access to the following works—whether buy, borrow, or scan them. Two important notes: (1) paper copies are *strongly encouraged* in class, but electronic versions are permitted; (2) I have chosen these books to be required to obtain because I believe they will serve you in ministry longterm. As such, I do recommend buying them over borrowing or scanning if finances allow.

- Athanasius. *On the Incarnation*. Translated by John Behr. Popular Patristics. Yonkers, NY: St.Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2011. (Amazon Link)
- Wellum, Stephen J. Wellum, *God the Son Incarnate: The Doctrine of Christ*. Foundations of Evangelical Theology. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2016. (Amazon Link)

[1] See Andrew David Naselli, *How to Understand and Apply the New Testament: Twelve Steps from Exegesis to Theology* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R Publishing, 2017), 5.

[2] Stephen R. Holmes, "The Nature of Theology and the Extent of the Atonement," *Perichoresis* 16.4 (2018): 11.

- You should have already purchased this for Theology 1: Jamieson, R. B., and Tyler R. Wittman. *Biblical Reasoning: Christological and Trinitarian Rules for Exegesis*. Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2022. (Amazon Link)
- You should have already purchased this for Theology 1: Webster, John. *God without Measure: Working Papers in Christian Theology*. Volume 1. *God and the Works of God*. London: Bloomsbury T&T Clark, 2016. (Amazon Link)

- ***All other readings will be made available as PDF scans on Populi by the professor.***

§4. COURSE APPROACH AND PEDAGOGY

This course will be a guided socratic dialogue, which will thus require your careful attention and thoughtful interaction in class. Because I desire to teach you not just *what* to think, but also *how* to think, you must interact in class, and you will only be able to do this well by first reading the assigned materials. While we will not get into every nook and cranny of theological investigation due to the minimal time we have together, my goal is to cover the "boundary markers" of the Christian religion with a Reformed bent, and then will we be able to scratch some of the surfaces of difficult theological questions. In our discussions, *I expect you to treat others as you would want to be treated, preeminently with the virtue of love. I will not tolerate uncharitable discourse in class*. It is a good policy to first correctly understand someone before one tries to offer a critique.

§5. COURSE REQUIREMENTS AND GRADING

Students will be evaluated according to the following requirements:

Reading:	40%
Participation:	10%
Church Ministry Project:	10%
Research Paper:	20%
Research Paper presentation:	10%
Weekly Comments/Questions:	10%

5.1 Reading (40%) — Students are required to complete assigned readings before class in order to receive credit for respective readings. Students will upload a reading log to populi indicating what percentage of readings they completed by the last day of class. This is 40% of your final grade for this course—I highly recommend that students prioritize completing the reading(s) as this will have a very significant impact on your overall grade.

5.1.1 A Note on Reading. Some professors may define "read" as "micro-read," that is, very carefully, paying close attention to everything. I do not expect this of you, but encourage it. I will expect you to read the material with honor and diligence such that you read carefully enough to understand what the author is saying (this doesn't mean you will retain everything). Hence, you don't need to read every word, sentence, paragraph, or page with equally close attention (it may mean you skim some parts, breeze over headings, or very carefully read and digest other parts—you will need to use your own discretion and discernment). However, *you must read close enough to generally get a sense of what the author argues and talks about*—such reading will count as full credit.

***5.2 Participation* (10%) —** Students will be graded on *active* participation in class. "*Active* participation" does not refer only to the *amount* of talking in class—one can speak excessively in class and such would not guarantee a high grade; rather, "*active* participation" primarily refers to the quality of questions and comments from students as well as *attentive* listening.

***5.3 Church Ministry Project* (10%) —** Students will need to sit down with someone in their local church for at least two times with their pastor during the semester to discuss one of the following topics: (1) Christology, (2) Pneumatology, (3) Soteriology, or (4) Eschatology.

***5.4 Weekly Comments/Questions* (10%) —** For each class, except the first class, students will be required to write i one thing they learned or have a question on or something they want to critique. They can submit this on Moodle.

***5.5 Research Paper* (20%) —** Students will turn in a final paper covering one (or more) specific topic within the broader categories taught in this course. In terms of methodology, each paper should address their topic starting with God and treating the topic of your choice in relation to God. You must write for the academic audience, including me and your classmates. Papers should exceed 3,000 words (not including footnotes). All students must follow the *SBL Handbook of Style* 2nd ed. Students must include a word count at bottom of the paper and upload a PDF to populi. Papers are graded upon a 100 point scale according to the rubric below.

5.6.1 Final Paper Rubric

Students' papers will be graded on …

1. Argumentation/Research (**75 pts**)
    - Use of Scripture
    - Integration of metaphysics or philosophical concepts
    - Logic
    - Proper and balanced use of resources
    - Covers the appropriate related aspects of doctrine in view
2. Well and clearly written (**10 pts**)
    - Proper grammar and syntax
    - Spelling
3. Church application—must be specific and concrete (**10 pts**)
4. Following the general guidelines of the *SBL Handbook of Style*, 2nd ed (**5 pts**)

***5.6 Research Paper Presentation* (10%) —** Every student will have to "present" or discuss the main idea of their paper, what you learned, and where your paper needs to improve in 3 minutes. Then, the student will answer questions from classmates and the professor for approximately 12 minutes.

§6. GRADING SCALE

The following scale will be used for final grades:

		B+	89–87	C+	79–77	D+	69–67		
A	100–94	B	86–84	C	76–74	D	66–64	F	59–0
A–	93–90	B–	83–80	C–	73–70	D–	63–60		

§7. COURSE PROTOCOLS & STANDARDS

Assignment Expectations

Students will turn in a completed PDF to the professor via Populi. Papers will be written according to standards found in the *SBL Handbook of Style*, 2nd ed.

Late Work

I have a ***NO*** late work policy. No work will be accepted if it is turned in late—past the due time—unless extreme circumstances bar you from turning it in on time. Extreme circumstances include things that are out of the ordinary that would excuse you from preaching on a Sunday morning if you were a pastor. Such examples include: death of a family member or friend, unusual illness, car accident, your dog ate your computer, and other similar occurrences. I do not intend this to be burdensome, but to help you prepare for future ministry. If you are going to be a pastor or church leader, sheep in the flock will depend on you to care and feed them God's word. Sometimes this means you will turn in unfinished or "not your best" work, but that is better than nothing at all.

Academic Honesty

Oahu Theological Seminary is committed to personal integrity and honesty. All instances of dishonesty or distorting the truth to avoid negative academic or social consequences are grounds for a disciplinary response. Therefore, a policy has been established in the event of cheating or plagiarism.

> *Cheating*
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> Students cheating in course work or examinations are subject to discipline. Cheating includes copying another student's work and presenting it as one's own (or allowing another person to copy one's own work) and using dishonest or prohibited methods to complete a test (or helping another person to cheat). Students who cheat will be subject to significant academic consequences including an immediate failing grade for the course. An offending student may also be put on disciplinary probation. For more details, please refer to the Student Handbook.
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> *Plagiarism*
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> Students found plagiarizing are subject to discipline. The most common errors in handling written sources are the following:
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> - failure to use quotation marks when quoting,
> - failure to make a thorough paraphrase when attempting to put the idea in one's own words,
> - failure to credit the source of the information
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> Students who are discovered to have plagiarized are subject to an immediate F for the course and possible disciplinary probation. For more details, please refer to the Student Handbook.

Special Needs

Any student who may require an accommodation under the provisions of the Americans with Disabilities Act should contact the course instructor in this matter as soon as possible and no later than the end of the first week of classes. Special needs must be documented with the staff of OTS

Syllabus Revision

The professor holds the right to change/revise the syllabus.

§8. SCHEDULE

SYSTEMATIC THEOLOGY 2 **Underlined reading(s) will drive the specific class discussion**			
Date & Topic	**Textbook Reading**	**Bible Reading**	**Assignment Due**
Oct 20th: Context & Metaphysics of the Incarnation	1. Athanasius, *On the Incarnation* §§1–18 2. Wellum, *God the Son Incarnate*, pp. 278–311 3. Sanders, "Introduction to Christology"	• John 1	• Student Questions
Oct 27th: Metaphysics & Hermeneutics of the Incarnation	1. Duby, *Jesus and the God of Classical Theism*, 141–153 2. Wellum, *God the Son Incarnate*, chs. 9 & 13 3. Jamieson & Wittman, *Biblical Reasoning*, chs. 7–8	• Phil 2 • Heb 1	• Student Questions
Nov 3rd: Intro to Salvation	1. Webster, *GWM*, ch. 10 2. Wellum, *God the Son Incarnate*, ch. 3 3. Beeke & Smalley, *Reformed Systematic Theology*, 3:267–283	• Rom 5:12–21	• Student Questions
Nov 10th: The Work of Christ	1. Athanasius, *On the Incarnation* §§19–32 2. Horton, *Pilgrim Theology*, 191–228 3. Turretin, *Institutes of Elenctic Theology*, XVI.v	• Matt 1–2 • Rom 3 • 1 Cor 15	• Student Questions
Nov 17th: The Spirit & Union with Christ	1. Mastricht, *Theoretical-Practical Theology*, 1.2.27 2. Calvin, *Institutes* 1.13.14–15; 3.1.1–4; 3.10.11 3. Johnson, *One with Christ*, ch. 1 4. Gaffin, "The Work of Christ Applied," in *Chr. Dogmatics*	• Eph 1–2	• Student Questions
Nov 24th: Justification, & Sanctification	1. Catholic Document Selections 2. Calvin, *Institutes*, III.xi.1–4 3. Bavinck, *The Wonderful Works of God*, chs. xxi–xxii 4. *Synopsis of a Purer Theology,* disp. 33	• Rom 4–5 • Gal 2–4	• Student Questions
Dec 1st: Eschatology: The Millennium & Beatific Vision	1. À Brakel, *The Christian's Reasonable Service*, 4:339–370 2. Bandy, "Views of the Millennium" 3. Augustine, *City of God*, XXII.29–30 4. Turretin, *Institutes of Elenctic Theology*, XX.viii	• Rev 20–22	• Final Paper (**Due Dec 3rd @ 11:59pm)**
Dec 8th: Paper Presentations	1. Jamieson and Wittman, *Biblical Reasoning*, conclusion 2. Classmate papers (Skim)		• Paper Presentations • Church Ministry Project